Lesson Plan: Short-Form Vertical Video for Digital Activism

Description of the lesson

This lesson serves as a practical, hands-on guide for leveraging short-form vertical video content to drive civic engagement, political commentary, and social activism.

The session explains why vertical video has become the dominant format for digital communication and how its full-screen orientation creates immediacy, urgency, and authenticity.

Participants will analyze a full taxonomy of short-form video styles, ranging from "boomer car rants" and multi-persona dialogues to satire, video essays, and "vox populi" interviews.

They will learn practical strategies for content creation, including the "Lookout Mindset," trend-jacking, steelmanning counter-arguments, and building structured scripts around the **Hook → Core → Call to Action** framework.

Furthermore, the lesson dives into psychological tactics such as using memes as "Trojan horses" to introduce complex or radical ideas, persona building, and leveraging confrontation to increase shareability.

Finally, participants will navigate the technical logistics, platform specifications (TikTok, Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts), publishing best practices, safety warnings, and strategies for avoiding algorithmic censorship or shadowbanning on sensitive political topics.

Learning objectives

By the end of the lesson, participants will be able to:

- **Understand main video formats:** Evaluate the pros, cons, and production requirements of six core vertical formats (monologue rants, dialogues, satire/sketches, video essays, reaction videos, and vox populi).
- **Apply strategic creation techniques:** Utilize the "Lookout Mindset," trend integration (e.g., pop culture icons), and AI-assisted "steelmanning" to refine messages.
- **Master psychological engagement tactics:** Implement the "Hook → Core → Call to Action" framework, use humor as a "Trojan horse" for serious messages, build relatable personas, and frame clear oppositional arguments.

- **Navigate technical specifications and censorship:** Adhere to platform time limits and caption overlays while avoiding safety hazards (e.g., filming while driving) and algorithmic penalty triggers on sensitive topics (e.g., war, political conflict).

Target group

Young creators, digital activists, NGO workers, communications students, and civic organizers who wish to translate social and political messages into viral, engaging short-form video formats.

Duration

Approximately 90 minutes.

- *60-minute version:* Focus exclusively on the video taxonomy and the "Hook → Core → Call to Action" structure; omit the hands-on storyboarding exercise.
- *120-minute version:* Extend the group activity into a live content creation workshop where groups record and edit a raw 60-second vertical video draft using their mobile phones, followed by a class screening.

Learning outcomes, content, teaching and learning methods, and evaluation methods

Learning outcomes	**Content**	**Teaching and learning methods**	**Evaluation methods**
Differentiate vertical video formats and their strategic uses	Mobile consumption trends; 6 video formats (Rants, Dialogues, Satire, Essays, Reacts, Vox Populi).	Visual presentation with real-world TikTok/Reels examples (e.g., @danesjenovdan).	Format identification quiz / Oral participation.
Apply messaging frameworks and psychological hooks	Hook → Core → Call to Action model; Trojan Horse tactics; Wojak relatability; steelmanning arguments; persona building.	Guided script breakdown; analysis of viral political hooks.	Completed script outline worksheet.

Learning outcomes	Content	Teaching and learning methods	Evaluation methods
Implement strategic trend-jacking and topic discovery	The “Lookout Mindset”; trend hijacking (e.g., Labubu, Breaking Bad); AI-assisted brainstorming.	Group brainstorming exercise using trending pop culture topics.	Quality of topic/trend pairings in group work.
Comply with platform rules, publishing tactics, and moderation	Platform limits (TikTok, Instagram, Shorts); caption placement; safety "don'ts"; navigating shadowbanning and sensitive topic censorship.	Lecture input; analysis of platform terms and suppressed keywords.	Quiz / Final checklist review.

Lesson structure

1. Introduction: The Vertical Revolution (10 minutes)

- **The Mobile Context:** Facilitator explains the shift from static to video based social media and presents key statistics: over 90% of social media consumption happens on mobile devices
- **Portrait vs. Landscape:** Highlighting the importance of device orientation as a major friction barrier. Visual contrast showing how vertical video claims 100% of screen real estate, creating a sense of intimacy, urgency, and raw authenticity.
- **Call to Action for Creators:** Introduce Robert Johnson’s quote: *"The world is run by those who show up."* Emphasize the importance of posting consistently on TikTok, Instagram, and YouTube Shorts.

2. Input 1: Taxonomy of Short-Form Video Formats (20 minutes)

The facilitator breaks down six primary formats, detailing their production lift and strategic advantages:

- **Monologue "Rants":** Direct-to-camera (e.g., "boomer car rants"). High emotional authenticity and fast production, but prone to audience fatigue/saturation.

- **Dialogues:** One creator playing two personas looking off-camera. Excellent for addressing talking points and counter-arguments in a controlled, entertaining way.
- **Sketches & Satire:** High viral potential. Uses humor to disarm prejudice.
- **Video Essays / Explainers:** Faceless format with off-camera voiceover over B-roll/graphics. Allows for deep policy dives without requiring on-camera presence, but demands intensive scripting.
- **React & Vox Populi:** "React" relies on drama-bait/provocation; "Vox Populi" (street interviews) yields high authenticity, though creators sacrifice some control over the final narrative.

3. Input 2: Strategy, Psychology, and Technical Tactics (25 minutes)

- **The Lookout Mindset & Trends:** Explain how creators must make use of “social listening” by scanning news feeds, comment sections as well as pop and online culture trends to detect and potentially hijack existing attention.
- **Crafting the Message:** Introduce "steelmanning"—anticipating and addressing the strongest version of an opponent's argument (using AI tools to test counter-points).
- **Psychological Hooks & Memes:**
    - *The Trojan Horse:* How humor/memes bypass audience defenses to deliver political ideology.
    - *Relatability (Wojak/"Literally Me"):* Showing genuine emotion, being unpolished, and using direct addresses ("you").
    - *Confrontation:* Content with a clear opponent is shared twice as much. "Pouring pure wine" (direct, bold honesty) builds trust.
- **Structure:** Every video must follow **Hook (First 3 seconds) → Core Message → Call to Action (CTA)**.
- **Technical Logistics & Warnings:**
    - *Specs:* TikTok (flexible), Instagram Reels (recommended up to 3 mins), YouTube Shorts (3 mins).
    - *Publishing:* Captions must place the hook on-screen in seconds 1–3. Descriptions should act as teasers with relevant keywords/hashtags.
    - *Safety & Censorship:* Never film while driving/biking. Beware of algorithmic suppression (shadowbanning) when discussing war, violence, or sensitive

conflicts (e.g., Israel/Palestine); use coded language ("algospeak") when necessary.

4. Group Activity: Scripting a Vertical Activist Video (20 minutes)

- **Task:** Participants work in groups of 3–4 to draft a script and storyboard for a 60-second vertical video addressing a civic or social issue.
- **Requirements:**
    1. Select one format from the taxonomy (e.g., Dialogue, Satire, or Explainer).
    2. Draft a **First 3-Second Hook** (visual + verbal).
    3. Incorporate a **Trojan Horse element** (trend, humor, or pop-culture reference).
    4. Identify a clear opponent or counter-argument (steelmanning).
    5. End with an actionable **Call to Action**.
- **Sharing:** Each group pitches their video concept to the class in 90 seconds.

5. Reflection and Closing (15 minutes)

- **Discussion Questions:**
    - How do we balance using "drama bait" or confrontation with maintaining ethical, truthful messaging?
    - How can activists discuss heavily moderated/censored political issues without getting their accounts penalized?
- **Summary:** Facilitator reviews the technical "don'ts" (audio quality, safety hazards, caption placement) and reiterates that consistency beats perfection in the short-form ecosystem.

Materials for teaching

Material	**Form / Details**
Presentation Slide Deck	Slides covering mobile statistics, horizontal vs. vertical comparison, video taxonomy, memes and illustrations (Wile E. Coyote, Trojan Horse, Wojak, Labubu).

Material	Form / Details
Video Case Studies	Downloaded clip examples for each of the 6 formats.
Scripting Worksheet	Printable template with fields for: *Format Choice*, *3-Second Hook*, *Trend Hijack*, *Core Message / Steelman*, and *Call to Action*.
Platform Spec Cheat Sheet	Reference card outlining video lengths, caption safety zones, and keyword optimization tips for TikTok, IG Reels, and YT Shorts.
Technical Equipment	Laptop, projector, audio speakers, and smartphones for participants.

Evaluation of the lesson

- **Formative Evaluation:** Facilitator assesses comprehension during the taxonomy presentation by asking participants to identify the formats of sample videos shown on screen.
- **Practical Application:** Evaluation of the completed Scripting Worksheets during the Group Activity to ensure correct integration of the **Hook → Core → CTA** framework and Trojan Horse strategies.
- **Peer Review:** Oral feedback during group pitches, evaluating whether the proposed first 3 seconds would successfully stop a user from scrolling.